What makes me think my coding abilities are up to the task?

I made my living as a programmer for 45 years, starting when I was eighteen years old. Do the math. I've been through every major computer and programming language change since the invention of C. I have been around the block and made a professional living at it.

Now I'm retired. I get to choose what I do, and I do it for me. This program was a real challenge for my programming chops. I probably couldn't have finished it in the four months I spent writing it without ChatGPT in the beginning and Google Gemini Pro at the end.

I used AI as a very focused documentation engine, but I always changed the code it suggested to match my own weird preferences. Unlike a lot of "vibe coders," nothing went into this program that I didn't understand and test personally. It was sometimes frustrating when you take an AI suggestion, find a bug, and the AI acts like it didn't give you that recommendation in the first place!

I also strongly believe in "dog-fooding" everything I code. I used this program to write this manual! I've used it, fixed things that got in my way, tested new things, and re-tested old things. I just ran it and worked on issues as they came up.

Part I: The Philosophy

"What were the rules I used to write this for authors?"

1. The Minimum Needed to Write It was a massive task to boil down everything writing software *allows* you to do into just what an author *needs* to do. I pared the fat down to the bone. If it doesn't put words on the page, it's gone.

2. The Cuts (Distractions)

Multiple Fonts: There isn't a need to use multiple fonts in a manuscript. If you need to indicate a computer speaking, use **Bold** or *Italics*. Fonts are for professional layout, not for drafting.

Checkboxes & Lists: This isn't a To-Do list application. If you need a checklist, use a notebook.

Colors: Nope. No text colors to play with. No color-coding the tree.

The Corkboard: *Sigh*. I love that feature in other apps. But it's a distraction, and it is far too easy to spend hours shuffling index cards when you should be writing scenes.

Version Control: If you are writing a draft, you know that. If you are writing a correction, you know that too. The software doesn't manage "snapshots" because that's just another form of procrastination.

3. The Essentials (The Tools)

Formatting: Bold, Italic, Underline, and Alignment (Left/Right/Center/Justify) are in there. That's it.

Structure: A robust Tree structure to keep track of your chapters and scenes? In there.

Focus: Full-screen, distraction-free editing? In there.

Environment: Dark/Light/System palette configuration? In there. For those of us with difficulty seeing, you can pick the font and character size for the whole novel. You need to be comfortable to write.

Safety: Background saving is standard. You don't have to stop typing to save; it happens silently so you never lose your work if the power goes out.

4. The "Fancy" Features (Allowed only because they help flow)

Text-to-Speech: It will read to you if you need it while editing. This is my only nod to "fancy" features because I use it religiously to catch rhythm errors.

Spell Check: Available, but *only when you ask for it*. No distracting red squiggles while you are trying to be creative.

Typing Sounds: Optional (for those who need the clack-clack of a typewriter to feel productive).

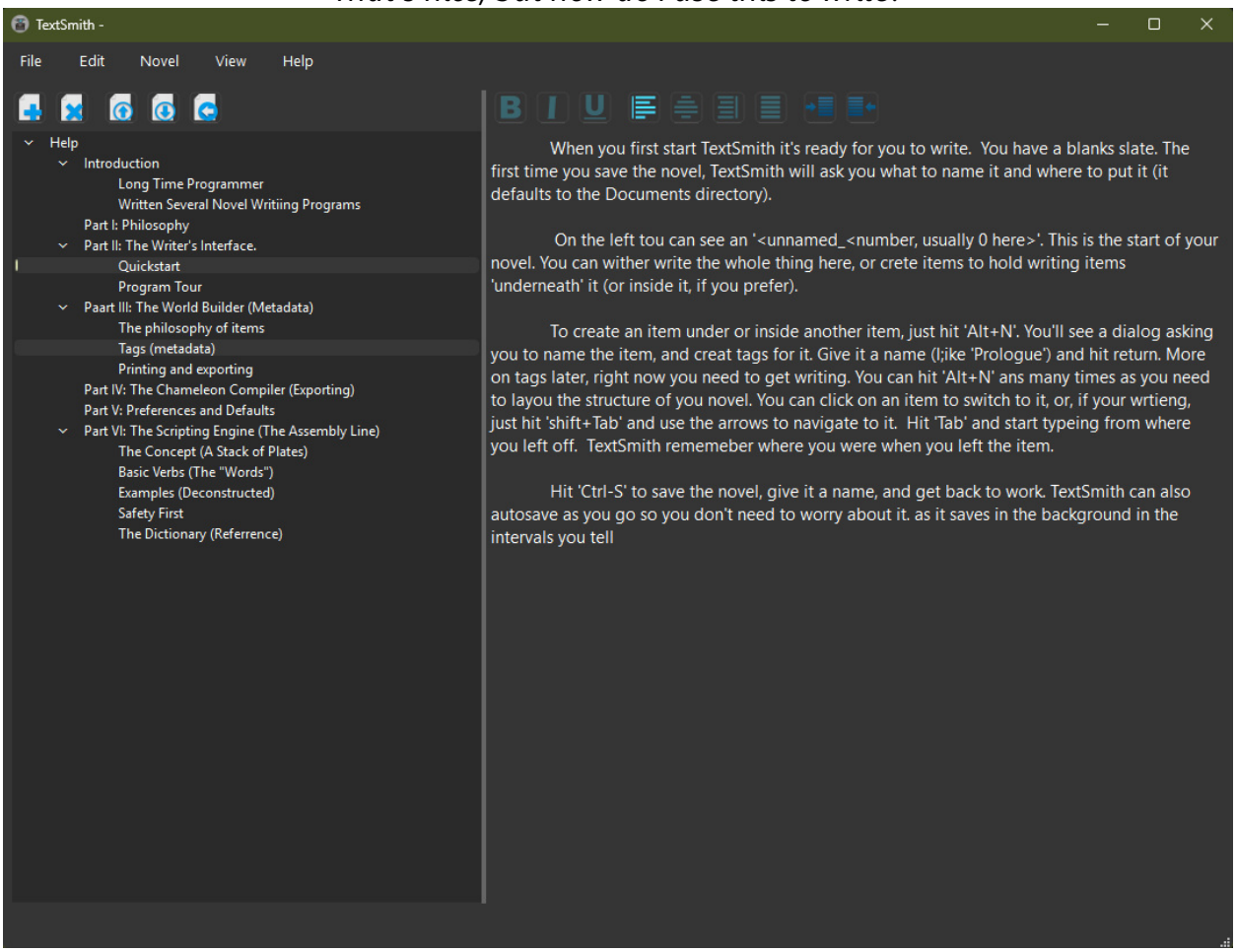
5. The Keyboard Rule Everything the program does is aimed at one thing: **Flow.** Everything you can do with the mouse is available at the keyboard so you can keep your eyes on the screen and your mind on the story. No bells, bings, or flashes unless you want them (and the flashes are a hard "No," sorry).

6. The Hidden Power (Scripting) The program is simple on the outside, but it hides powerful customization. There is a scripting language built in. It's not Python or Lua; it's

a language written by me to be intuitive, stack-based, and simple.
The Parity Principle: If you can do it with the mouse or keyboard, a script can do it, too.
The Restriction: You *cannot* edit scripts inside this program. That's coding, not writing. If you need a tool, write the script in a text editor and import it. This keeps the "Novel Writer" separate from the "Tool Builder."

Part II: The Writer's Interface

"That's nice, but how do I use this to write?"



When you first start TextSmith, it's ready for you to write. You have a blank slate. The first time you save the novel, TextSmith will ask you what to name it and where to put it (it defaults to your Documents directory).

On the left, you will see an item named **<unnamed_0>**. This is the start of your novel.

You can either write your whole book right here, or create new items to hold your writing "underneath" it (or inside it, if you prefer).

To create an item under (or inside) another item, just hit **Alt+N**. You'll see a dialog asking you to name the item and create tags for it. Give it a name (like 'Prologue') and hit Enter.

We will talk more about tags later; right now, you need to get writing.

You can hit **Alt+N** as many times as you need to lay out the structure of your novel.

Moving Around:

You can click on any item in the tree to switch to it.

The Keyboard Way: If you are writing and don't want to reach for the mouse, hit **Shift+Tab** to jump over to the tree, and use your arrow keys to navigate to the item you want. Hit **Tab** to jump back into the editor and start typing.

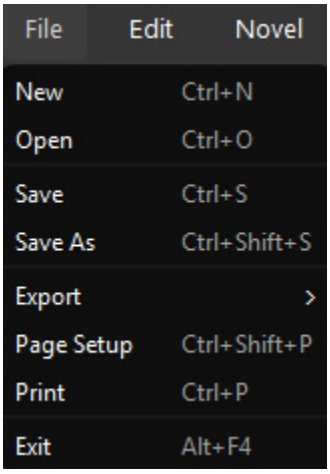
TextSmith remembers exactly where you left off in each item.

Saving: Hit **Ctrl+S** to save the novel, give it a name, and get back to work. TextSmith also autosaves as you go—saving quietly in the background at the intervals you tell it to—so you don't need to worry about losing your work.

The Menus

There are five main menus (File, Edit, Novel, View, and Help). Let's go through them in order and describe what each one does.
A quick note: TextSmith goes to great lengths to only enable menu selections that make sense at any given time. This reduces the classic "what-just-happened?" problem by preventing you from clicking things you shouldn't.

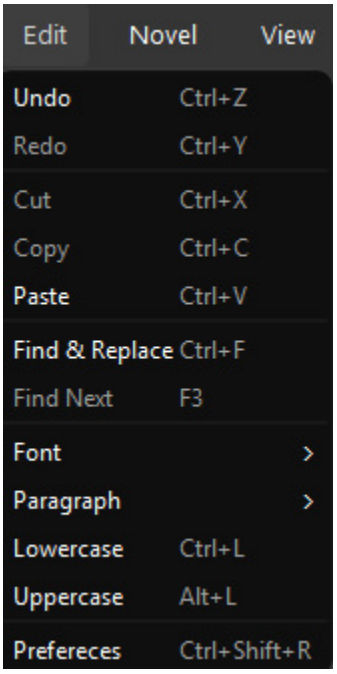
The File Menu



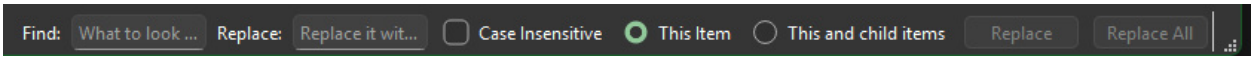
The File menu is where all things file-related go.
New (Ctrl+N): Start a new novel. If your current novel has unsaved changes, TextSmith will ask if you want to save them, discard them, or cancel the command. (The default action is Save, of course!)
Open (Ctrl+O): Open an existing novel. Just like 'New', it will ask you to save any current changes so you don't unknowingly lose your work. The document will open exactly where you left off when you last saved it.
Save (Ctrl+S): Saves your work to the current file. If you've never saved it before, it will ask you for a filename. You can cancel if you change your mind, but TextSmith will remember that the document is still unsaved.
Save As (Ctrl+Shift+S): Saves the novel under a brand new name.
Export (Ctrl+E ...: Export the current novel into one of the following formats: EPub (...Ctrl+E), HTML (...Ctrl+H), Markdown (...Ctrl+M), PDF (...Ctrl+P), or RTF (...Ctrl+R, most word processors like Microsoft Word and LibreOffice Writer can read RTF files).
Page Setup (Ctrl+Shift+P): Set up your margins, headers, and footers for printing your

documents.
Print (Ctrl+P): Send the novel to the printer.
Exit (Alt+F4): Leave the program. If you have unsaved changes, TextSmith will step in to keep you from losing any work before it closes.

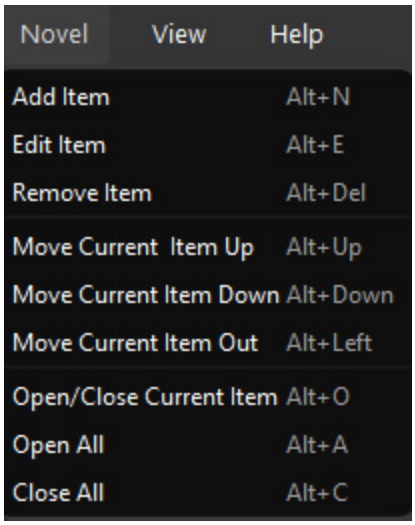
The Edit Menu



The Edit menu is where you find typical—and sometimes not-so-typical—text editing tools.
Undo (Ctrl+Z): Undo the last thing you did. The program keeps track of your actions like a stack of plates, letting you undo them in the exact reverse order you did them.
Redo (Ctrl+Y): If you undid something you wish you hadn't (perhaps from an overzealous string of Ctrl+Z keypresses), Redo lets you walk that back, putting things back on the "stack of plates"—as long as you haven't typed anything new yet.
Cut (Ctrl+X): Take the highlighted text, copy it to your paste buffer, and delete it from the editor.
Copy (Ctrl+C): Same as Cut, except the highlighted text is left exactly where it is.
Paste (Ctrl+V): Takes whatever is in your paste buffer (from anywhere on your computer) and plops it into TextSmith. This may involve stripping out a lot of formatting fluff if it's coming from a complex webpage or program. TextSmith does have limited image handling, so give it a try!
Find & Replace (Ctrl+F): This reveals a search bar at the bottom of the display. Type what you want to find and press Return. You can easily replace the found text with whatever you type in the replace field, or even replace all occurrences at once.



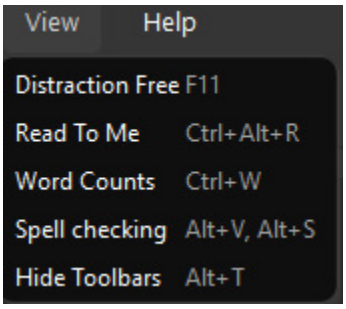
Find Next (F3): If you've already searched for something, this jumps directly to the next occurrence.
Font: Not exactly what you think! This simply lets you toggle **Bold (Ctrl+B)**, *Italic (Ctrl+I)*, and Underline (Ctrl+U) on your selected text.
Paragraph (Ctrl+J ...): Align your text (Left (...Ctrl+L) , Center (...Ctrl+C), Right (...Ctrl+R), Justify (...Ctrl+J)) or change the indentation (Indent, Unindent). Note: Left is sometimes called "ragged right", and Right is sometimes called "ragged left", just to confuse things.
Lowercase (Ctrl+L): Change the selected text to entirely lowercase.
Uppercase (Alt+L): Change the selected text to entirely uppercase.
Preferences (Ctrl+Shirt+R): Lets you set your default program settings. This includes the editor font, autosave intervals, text-to-speech voices, and more. (More on preferences later in the tour!).
The Novel Menu



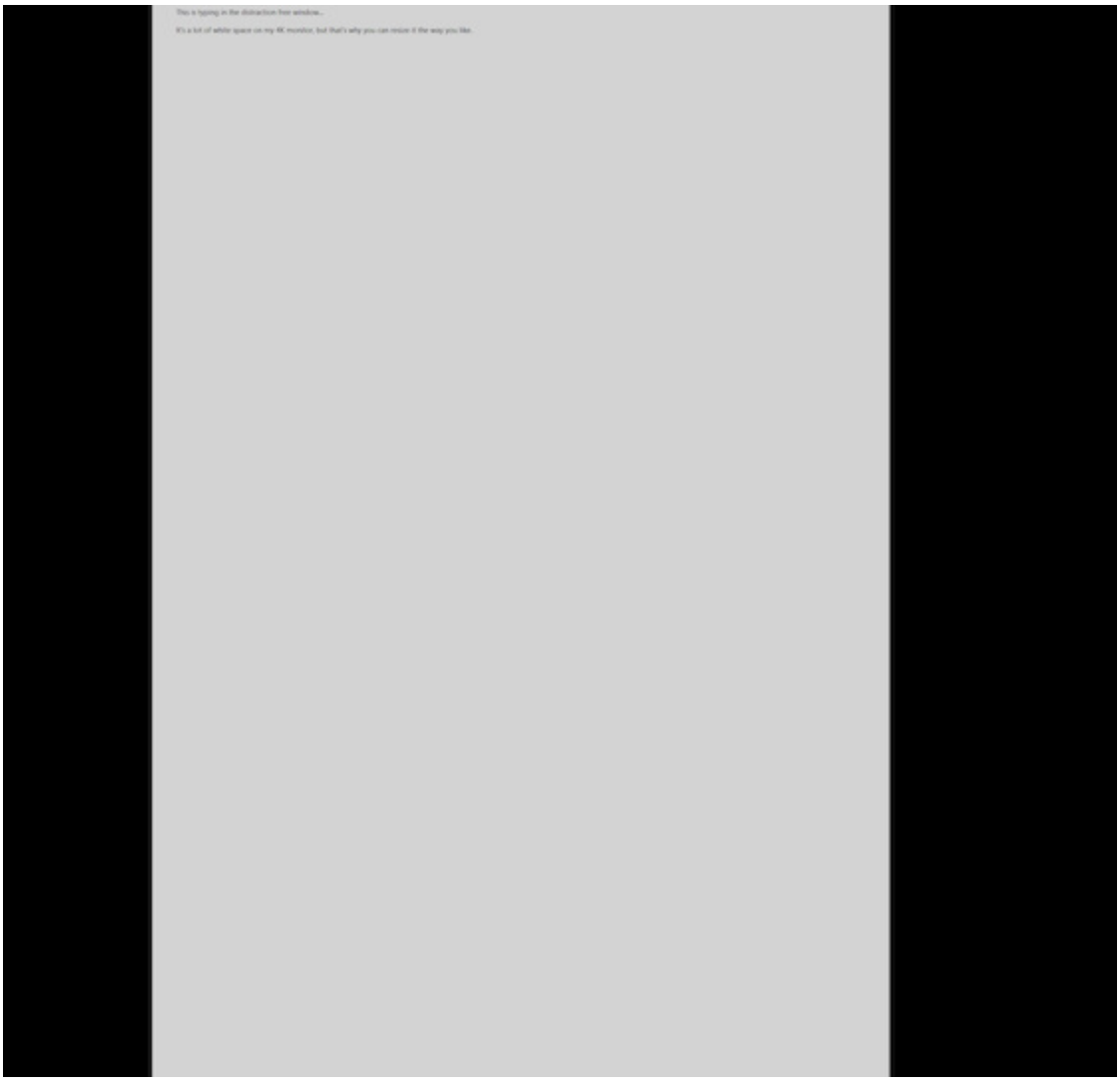
This menu handles the structure and organization of your novel's items.
Add Item (Alt+N): Adds a new item underneath your current one, allowing you to name it and assign tags.
Edit Item (Alt+E): Allows you to change the name and tags of an existing item.
Remove Item (Alt+Del): Deletes an item. Don't worry, you can use Undo if you make a mistake. You are welcome!
Move Current Item Up (Alt+Up): Moves the current item higher up in the document tree. If it reaches the top of its current parent group, it will "pop out" and move above its parent.
Move Current Item Down (Alt+Down): Moves the item down the tree, or out of its parent group if it reaches the bottom.
Move Current Item Out (Alt+Left): For when your nested lists get too deep, this simply promotes the item directly out of its current parent folder.
Open/Close Current Item (Alt+O): Expands the current item to see its children, or

collapses it to hide them.
Open All (Alt+A): Expands every single item in your document tree. It can be nice to see the whole structure, or it might just be overwhelming.
Close All (Alt+C): If "Open All" was too much, this collapses everything. Take a deep breath and start opening things one at a time.

The View Menu



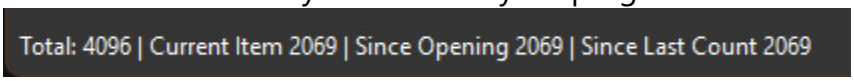
This menu controls how you look at your writing environment.
Distraction Free (F11): This brings up the distraction-free window. I develop TextSmith on a 4K monitor (actually, it's an old TV I got for free, which is great for vision issues), so my screen has a lot of empty space. Distraction-free mode dynamically adjusts to your monitor to give you a clean slate. You can drag the margins to make it look exactly like a page, and it completely blocks out the main TextSmith window until you hit ESC or F11 to exit.



Features in this mode: You can type, use basic text editing (cut, copy, paste, undo, redo, formatting), and check your word counts at the bottom of the left-hand bar. If you've enabled typing sounds in your preferences, you'll hear them here.

Read To Me (Ctrl+Shift+R): Starts reading the current item out loud using your operating system's selected text-to-speech voice. (If your OS doesn't have text-to-speech installed, it won't work—I can't program that part… yet!)

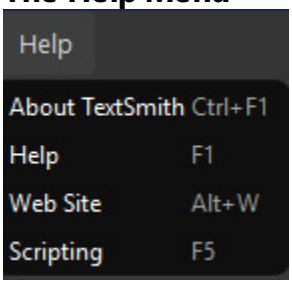
Word Counts (Ctrl+W): Displays your current word counts clearly in the left part of the bottom status bar so you can track your progress.



Spell Checking (Alt+V, Alt+S): TextSmith only checks your spelling when you explicitly ask it to. No distracting red squiggles while you write! When activated, it will highlight unrecognized words (Currently loaded with an English dictionary, but more can be

added if there's a demand!).
Show/Hide Toolbar: For even less distraction, or to give you some mouse-able quick aids, this menu option will show or hide the toolbars.

The Help Menu



About TextSmith (Ctrl+F1): Displays a quick blurb about the program and shows my appreciation for everyone who helped me along the way.
Help (F1): Opens this exact manual! Nice, huh?
Web Site (Alt+W): Takes you to my website so you can grab the most current version of TextSmith.
Scripting (F5): Shows you the loaded and available scripts. These are tools you can use to automate particular tasks or add features I didn't include out of the box. (More on this in the scripting section!)
The Toolbars

The toolbars in TextSmith are a visual shortcut, putting your most-used actions front and center while showing you the state of the text editor at a glance. As a bonus, hovering the mouse over any button will tell you its keyboard shortcut.
From left to right, here is what the buttons do:
Add Item: Adds a new item underneath your current one, allowing you to name it and assign tags.
Remove Item: Deletes the current item.
Move Current Item Up: Moves the current item higher up in the document tree. If it reaches the top of its current parent group, it will "pop out" and move above its parent.
Move Current Item Down: Moves the item down the tree, or out of its parent group if it reaches the bottom.
Move Current Item Out: For when your nested lists get too deep, this simply promotes the item directly out of its current parent folder.
Bold: Indicates if the current text style is bold. Clicking it toggles the bold state for selected text or text you are about to type.
Italic: Indicates if the current text style is italic. Clicking it toggles the italic state.

Underline: Indicates if the current text style is underlined. Clicking it toggles the underline state.
Left: Aligns the current paragraph to the left.
Center: Centers the current paragraph.
Right: Aligns the current paragraph to the right.
Justify: Aligns the current paragraph to both the left and right margins.
Indent: Increases the indentation of the current paragraph.
Outdent: Decreases the indentation of the current paragraph (down to zero, but no further).
One final note: You can show and hide the toolbars as needed for focus or editing space. My personal recommendation is to leave them on; if you need fewer distractions, try the **Distraction Free Mode** (F11) instead.

The Document Tree

If the Editor is where the words live, the Document Tree is where your story lives. This panel on the left side of the screen shows you the entire structure of your novel at a glance.

The Single Root Rule

TextSmith enforces a "Single Root" structure. This means every single item in your novel —every chapter, scene, character note, or setting description—must hang off the main title of your project. You cannot have "floating" chapters outside the book.
The Root: The very top item is your Novel itself. You cannot delete this (unless you want to delete the whole project!), but you can rename it to whatever working title you prefer.
The Hierarchy: Everything else is a "child" of that root, or a child of a child. This lets you nest scenes inside chapters, chapters inside parts, and character sheets inside a "Notes" folder.

Opening and Closing Items

To keep your view clean, you can expand or collapse any part of the tree.
Click the Arrow: Clicking the small arrow (or +/- symbol) next to an item will reveal or hide its children.

Moving Items

We already covered moving items using the **Menu** and **Toolbar** (Move Up, Down, In, and Out), but the Document Tree also fully supports **Drag and Drop** for when you need to make big structural changes.
Reordering: Click and hold an item, then drag it between two other items. You will see a line appear indicating where it will land. Release the mouse to drop it into its new place.
Reparenting: If you drag an item *directly onto* another item, it will become a child of that item. This is the fastest way to move a loose scene into a specific chapter.
Notes:
Double Click: You can also simply double-click the item itself to toggle it open or closed.
Just like with the toolbar buttons, TextSmith tries to be smart about where items can go.

It won't let you drag a parent inside its own child (which would create a time-travel paradox that crashes the universe), but otherwise, you are free to organize your book exactly how you see fit.

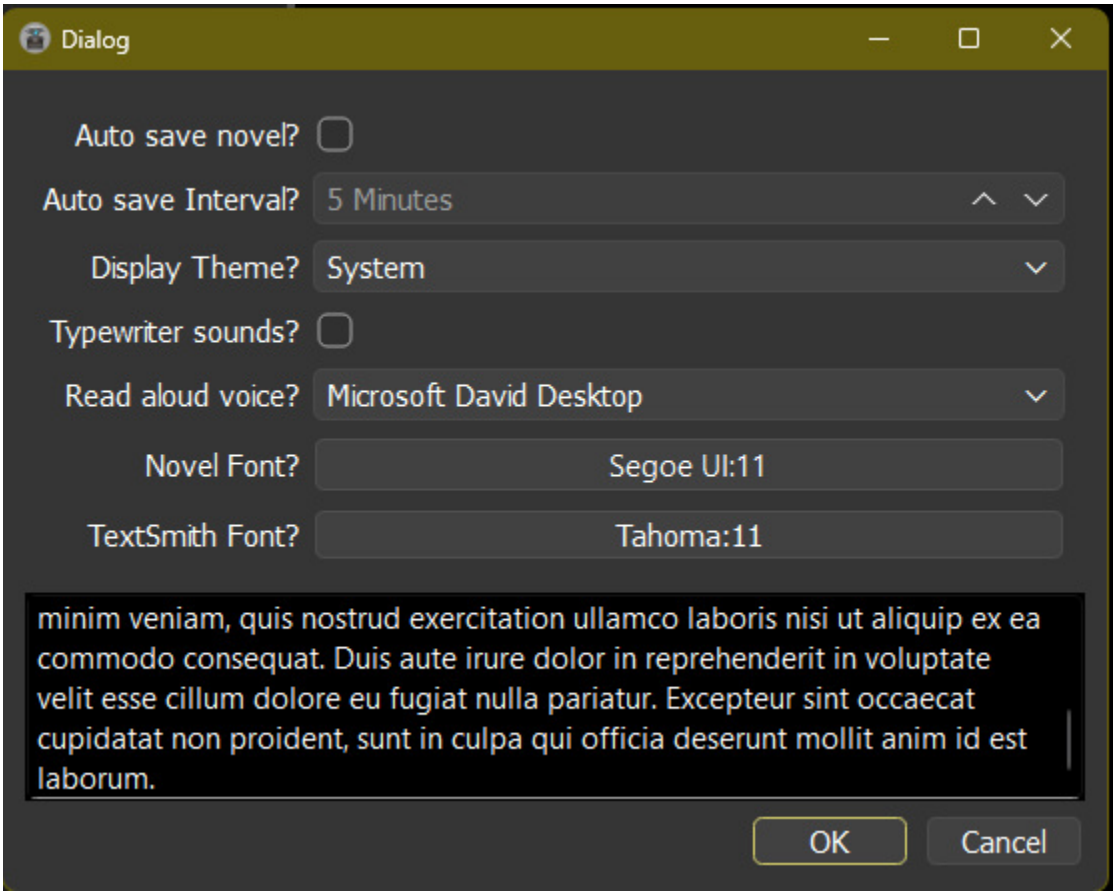
The Text Editor

The Text Editor is exactly what it sounds like: the main stage where you actually write your novel.

If you have used any word processor in the last thirty years, you already know how to use this one. You click, you type, you highlight, you copy, and you paste. The standard keyboard shortcuts (Ctrl+C, Ctrl+V, Ctrl+Z, etc.) all do exactly what you expect them to do.

There are no hidden tricks, strange formatting rules, or proprietary hurdles here. It is just a clean, responsive, and familiar space designed to get out of your way so you can focus on getting your words onto the page.

Preferences: Set It and Forget It



The next really important thing in TextSmith2 is the Preferences dialog. This is the only place you can fiddle with the application settings, and by design, there just isn't much here to change. Enjoy customizing it, but hopefully, you get bored with it quickly and go

back to writing.
Here is what you can configure:
Auto Save: Toggle automatic saving on or off, and set the time interval (e.g., every 5 minutes) to ensure you never lose your progress.
Display Theme: Choose between Light, Dark, or let the app match your Operating System defaults.
Typewriter Sounds: Toggle this on if you need that classic, tactile audio feedback to get into the writing zone… only in fullscreen mode!
Read Aloud Voice: Pick your preferred reader from the available text-to-speech voices installed on your system.
Typography:
Novel Font: Sets the typeface and size for your actual manuscript. When you change this, the sample text box at the bottom of the dialog updates instantly so you can preview the look.
TextSmith Font: Sets the user interface font for the application itself. The Preferences dialog will update immediately so you can see the change, but the rest of the application won't apply the new UI font until you click **OK**.

Part II: The World Builder (Metadata)
"But how do I tell a Scene from a Chapter, from Junk?"

The Philosophy of Items

TextSmith is unusual among novel-writing software because it places absolutely no restrictions on what a unit of writing is called. For the sake of this manual, let's just call a unit of writing an "item"—mostly because it's a lot easier to say than "unit of writing." Each item can be exactly what you need it to be. You can place items inside of other items, building out the exact framework your story requires.

You use them for what you want. You are completely in control.

We all know that novels are made up of many moving parts, the bulk of them typically being chapters and scenes. TextSmith doesn't demand that a chapter actually be called a chapter. It defaults to that, but you are free to call a chapter whatever you want: *C*, *Chap*, or even *Fred*. It really doesn't care.

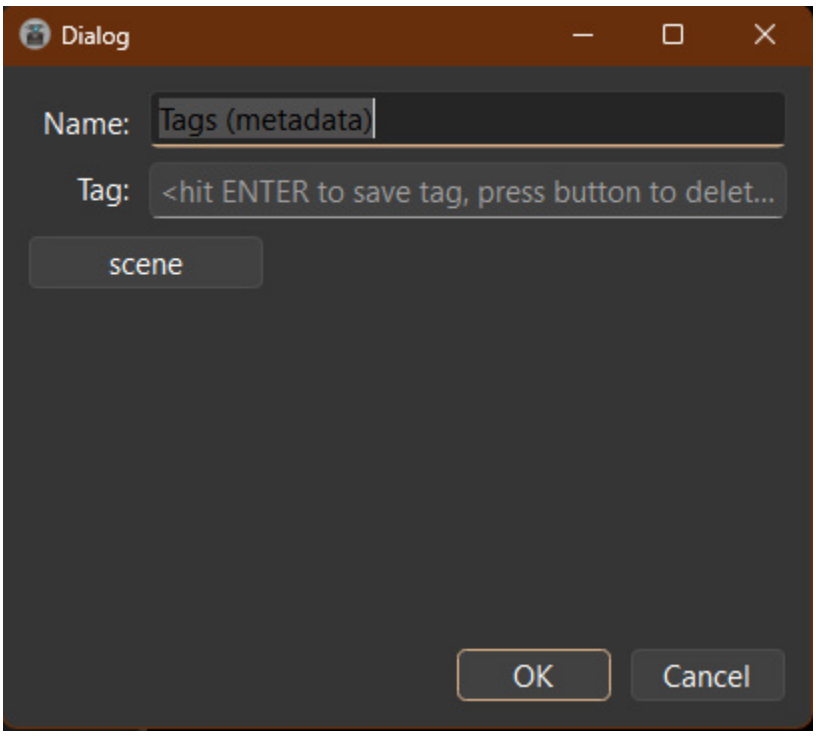
The exact same thing goes for scenes. You get to pick the terminology, and once you do, TextSmith remembers it.

Tags (Metadata): Giving Your Items Meaning

How do you name things? Glad you asked. Each item has a **Name** (for example, '*Karl meets Isabella*'). These names are strictly for you, the author. They are what appears in your document tree to keep you organized, but they will *never* appear in the actual text when you print or export your novel.

How do you assign meaning to an item? Good question. The answer is in the exact same place you give the item its name. The meaning you give an item is called a **Tag**. Because an item can have many meanings or serve many purposes, it can have multiple tags. (We will get into some cool and useful examples of this when we talk about printing and exporting).

The Nitty-Gritty: How it Works How do you do all this magical stuff? Selecting **Edit Item** (or creating a **New Item**) brings up the dialog box shown below:



The Name Field: This is simply the title of the item, as mentioned above. *Pro-tip:* If you hit the Return/Enter key while your cursor is in this field, the dialog will immediately save and close. I've found this incredibly handy when you want to rapidly add multiple items in a row.

The Tag Field: Moving to the next line is how you assign meaning. Type something—anything—and hit Enter. It will instantly appear as a button below the text line, leaving you ready to type another tag. To delete a tag, simply click its button.

What can you tag? Almost anything. I've used tags to keep track of characters, designate scenes, flag items for a particular export type, or mark the timeline of when an event occurs in the novel. If you can think of a way to organize your story, a tag can probably be used for it.

Saving: Any changes you make in this window are on hold until you hit **OK**. If you hit **Cancel**, your changes are gone forever.

Wow. Now you have a snazzy document written. Now what?

How about you print it out?

Part IV: The Chameleon Compiler (Exporting)

"*The wierd and wacky world of document foramts*"

Part V: Defaults

"How TextSmith remebers things"

Part VI: The Scripting Engine (The Assembly Line)

"Here there be dragons!"

Author's Note: You can skip this entire section. > You can use TextSmith perfectly fine for the rest of your life without ever reading a single word of Part VI. If the idea of writing code makes you break out in hives, turn back now. This section is strictly for the code monkeys who write fiction on the side and want absolute, programmatic control over how their manuscript is assembled.